

large user base. Consumers were now presented with a plethora of options in terms of form factors, screen sizes and hardware features while developers had unprecedented control over their apps and a large target audience to monetize their work.

Android's meteoric rise to power in the mobile space, however, was met with criticism from experts who complained about Android fragmentation, greater susceptibility to malware infections and app piracy—all offshoots of the open nature of the platform.

History

Android.inc, a startup specializing in software development for mobile devices, was acquired by Google in 2005. Many interpreted this as a sign that Google was coming out with its own phone, the gPhone, to promote its ad business on mobile devices. However, Google denied such claims and co-founder of Android Inc. (and later head of Android Development at Google) Andy Rubin stated that it was aiming at a software development platform that would enable hundreds of devices to run Android and create a user experience that was unheard of. This was followed by the formation of the Open Handset Alliance (OHA) in 2007, which was a consortium of several companies led by Google that pledged the formation and promotion of an open software platform for mobile devices. The OHA included handset manufacturers, semiconductor companies, software companies and mobile carriers in addition to Google itself, all of whom believed in an open mobile ecosystem that would foster rapid innovation, ultimately benefitting all the parties involved and delivering a superior mobile user experience to end users. Prominent companies such as HTC, Intel, Qualcomm, Broadcom, Samsung, Motorola, Nvidia, T-Mobile and Sprint Nextel, among others, were part of the initiative. Presently the OHA has a total of 84 members with Android being the first of many projects towards the goal of providing open standards for mobile applications.

According to the OHA, Android was “built from the ground-up to enable developers to create compelling mobile applications that take full advantage of all a handset has to offer. It was built to be truly open”. Based on the open source and vastly popular Linux kernel, Android allowed developers to easily create and deploy apps, using the Android SDK. The SDK was released by Google as part of the Android Open Source Project (AOSP), which also aims to maintain compatibility between different devices running the Android Operating System.